

Academic Writing: Dos and Don'ts

The main objective of using academic language is to present complex facts in a simple, comprehensible way in order to make them accessible to an expert or interested lay audience. This is done by applying an objective writing style that makes use of simple sentence structures as well as precise and concise vocabulary. The table below gives an overview of the features of academic writing:

Academic Writing Style		
	To AVOID	RECOMMENDED
Syntax	Long, nested sentences	Short sentences that contain a maximum of one thought . First-degree subordinate clauses at most. A sentence must be comprehensible at first reading.
Lexis	• Synonyms for technical terms • Colloquialisms (spoken language), idioms, slang • Contractions (<i>doesn't, hasn't</i>) • Unspecific, vague expressions (<i>very big, really important, a little bit etc.</i>) • Phrasal verbs (e.g. <i>look at</i> → <i>examine</i>) • Chapter = part of a book	• Consistent and repeated use of technical terms → Define terms • Formal language (<i>does not...</i>) • Precise and concise language • Academic vocabulary (often of Latinate or Greek origin) • Section = part of a paper
Objectivity	• I and we • One... (<i>One has to consider...</i>) • Judgements: <i>luckily, surprisingly, impressively</i> • Unproven 'certainties' or facts	• Impersonal, objective language by using passives and impersonal subjects (<i>This report focuses on...</i>) • Well-founded judgements / opinions in the discussion section of the paper • Verifiable statements • Cautious or tentative language (<i>seem, appear, indicate, suggest, possibly, could, might</i>)
Information density	• Truisms (widely known facts not worth mentioning) • Low density of information • Repetitions • Fillers (<i>of course, naturally, obviously etc.</i>) • Long-winded explanations	• Only relevant facts • High density of information • To the point

Paragraphs	Paragraphs which - cover several topics - have no topic focus - use no linking.	Well-structured paragraphs with one central assertion. Transitions within and across paragraphs by using linking devices that facilitate the reading process (<i>on the one hand, ... on the other hand, in addition to</i> etc.)
Numbers and measurements	34'000 0,7km 16cm 83 %	34,000 0.7 km 16 cm 83% In general text, isolated numbers less than 10 should be spelled out. However, in equations, tables, figures, and other display elements, Arabic numerals should be used.
Tables	No numbering No heading Unclear or incomplete information - Table used as substitute for discussion of data	Clear, concise heading above the table → Information must be clear without having to read the running text. Chronological numbering throughout the text: <i>Table 1, Table 2...</i> Legend of the symbols, colors etc. used Discussion of the table content with precise reference in the running text (<i>As can be seen in Table 2 ...</i>)
Figures	No numbering No heading Unclear or incomplete information - Used as substitute for running text	Clear, concise heading below the figure → Information must be clear without having to read the running text. Chronological numbering throughout the text: <i>Fig. 1, Fig. 2...</i> Legend of the symbols, colors etc. used Discussion of the figure content with precise reference in the running text (<i>As Fig. 2 illustrates...</i>)
Equations	No numbering Heading	Chronological numbering in round brackets on the right side of the equation: (1)

- No heading

Checklist for Effective Academic Documents

Before you submit your work, check that it includes these features of good academic writing:

Content

- ☐ Is the title clear and informative?
- ☐ Is your work placed in context?
- ☐ Is the aim of your study stated clearly?
- ☐ Is the theoretical framework outlined?
- ☐ Are any research hypotheses stated clearly?
- ☐ Have you covered all the points required?
- ☐ Has all the material been checked for accuracy?

Structure

- ☐ Does the structure follow the requirements of the subject?
- ☐ Does the introduction outline the importance of the work and provide the necessary background information?
- ☐ Does the method section explain what was done and how it was done?
- ☐ Does the result section explain what was found?
- ☐ Does the discussion section interpret and explain the results?
- ☐ Does the discussion show how the results relate to aims/hypotheses set out in the introduction? What about the reliability of the results?
- ☐ Does the conclusion summarise the method and results, discuss the implications of the results and suggest improvements in future research?
- ☐ Does the reference list include only the references you have actually used?

Format

- ☐ Is the format appropriate for the discipline and the task?
- ☐ Have you followed the guidelines set out by your instructor (length of paper, referencing system)?
- ☐ Are the headings uniform and spaced consistently?
- ☐ Are the figures, tables and diagrams clearly labelled and appropriately placed?
- ☐ Have you referred to all the figures, diagrams and graphs you have included?
- ☐ Is data in graphs or tables also explained in words and analysed?
- ☐ Have all illustrations and figures taken from someone else's work been cited correctly?
- ☐ Has every idea taken from or inspired by someone else's work been acknowledged with a reference?

Style

- ☐ Is the writing clear, concise and objective?
- ☐ Is the writing fluent?
- ☐ Have you checked that you have not used emotive language such as *'This is a really exciting result.'*?
- ☐ Have you made sure that you have not used colloquial language such as *'We got these answers....'* or used contractions (*'It's important...'*)?
- ☐ Have you demonstrated your understanding of the sources you have used?

Grammar, spelling and punctuation

- ☐ Is the grammar correct?
- ☐ Are the tenses used appropriately?
- ☐ Are all the words spelled correctly and consistently so?
- ☐ Are upper-/lowercase letters used consistently?
- ☐ Are punctuation marks used correctly?

Useful Links for Writing Research Papers in English

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|---------------------------------|---|
| General | <ul style="list-style-type: none">• http://www.uefap.com/writing (extensive guide)• https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/purdue_owl.html (Purdue online writing lab) |
| Phrases & vocabulary | <ul style="list-style-type: none">• www.phrasebank.manchester.ac.uk/ (phrases for the various sections of a report or paper, see menu at the top and left of website, highly recommended!)• www.phrasebank.manchester.ac.uk/describing-quantities (phrases to describe quantities)• www.eliteediting.com.au/50-linking-words-to-use-in-academic-writing/ (linking expressions)• http://cc.oulu.fi/~smac/TRW/commonverb_handout.htm (verbs typically used in reports) |
| Grammar & tenses | <ul style="list-style-type: none">• http://cc.oulu.fi/~smac/TRW/tense_handout.htm (tenses)• https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_writing/punctuation/index.html (commas etc.)• https://ucalgary.ca/student-services/student-success/writing-support#collapse939131191 (grammar, punctuation, see bottom of website) |
| Referencing | <ul style="list-style-type: none">• http://libraryguides.vu.edu.au/ieeereferencing/gettingstarted (IEEE) |
| Unit Symbols (IEEE) | <ul style="list-style-type: none">• https://mentor.ieee.org/myproject/Public/mytools/draft/styleman.pdf (IEEE) |
| Translator | <ul style="list-style-type: none">• www.deepl.com/translator (quite reliable for formal writing, but always check!) |